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"I thought it was a hit-and-run. They would fire and go away. I am sad I wasn't martyred."

BIPLAB MALAKAR

poured out soaking his battle fatigues. He passed out.

Arvind Kumar, meanwhile, went down on the ground, fired his AK-47 and crawled—the standard drill to evade bullets. But the ground offered no cover. The men were being scythed down in groups as they lay prone. It soon became clear why. "*Ped se fire aa rahi hain* (they are firing from the trees)," Havaladar Major Ram Kumar Meena screamed as two Maoist light machine guns began thumping deadly fire from atop trees over 100 metres away.

Explosions from IEDs rent the air and smoke wafted across the field. Arvind's AK-47 ran out of ammunition.

"Take my magazines, I can't fire," a dying Sub-Inspector B.K. Sharma offered him two AK-47 magazines. As the battle raged, the Maoists were shouting tactical instructions to each other. "*Deepak, idhar se ghero*, (surround them from here)." It was a sight that was both terrifying and surreal. There were hundreds of tribal villagers around the field. They were screaming in Gondi, waving sticks and spears. It was like a royal *shikaar* which had converged onto a single killing field. It seemed like over a thousand people were firing though the Maoists claim they were only 300. "If I'm going to die, I'm going to try and take as many of them," Arvind thought as he and a few others began blasting away at the trees. He saw at least one of the Maoists falling off.

Then the firing came in from a small hillock towards the rear of the company. Arvind had attracted the deadly attention of their ambushers. A second grenade was flung towards him and it exploded near him. Three bullets hit him on the back. He collapsed on his rifle.

It was like the Maoists anticipated how the CRPF would react when ambushed. The field had turned into a killing box ringed with automatic weapons. It was a Roman colosseum. There was no retreat for these dying gladiators. In the firefight, which lasted for over three hours, the CRPF men were clinically finished off. And all that happened right in front of their own 'countrymen'. The last thing the survivors remember is seeing sari-clad tribal women moving in and stripping the bodies of their fallen comrades of their weapons.

Only seven men survived to tell this tale, one that would haunt them for the rest of their lives.

Warfare (CTJW) College in Kanker, 200 km south of state capital Raipur, can make a difference. Just three weeks ago, these men used to be regular lathi-wielding policemen. Now, they are a combat force ready to take on the Maoists. "It has given us the confidence to fight the Maoists," says Manager Singh, a Chhattisgarh police recruit, who at 41 is the oldest in a group of 375. Age has not dimmed his appetite for learning. And the brigadier's warning about the wooden boxes looms large.

The training is intense and tough. The emphasis is on physically toughening the recruits. Of the 45 days, 16 days and 14 nights are spent in the open. The recruits live in tents, just as they would on long patrols. "We tell the boys that they are the weapons," Ponwar says. Merely emphasising on equipment is not enough. "Just as buying a sitar will not make you Ravi



“ At CTJW college, we train our policemen to be knowledgeable and fearless in the face of the enemy. The war begins at our gates. ”

**BRIGADIER (RETD.) B.K. PONWAR,
DIRECTOR, CTJW COLLEGE, KANKER**

Shankar, giving an AK-47 to a policeman will not turn him into a commando," says a special forces officer.

Training or no training, the war has to be fought and governments can't wait for a perfect solution. The Centre, therefore, has to rush in the CRPF and the BSF. And they aren't training either, which is why every tragedy in Lalgarh or Chhattisgarh is followed by a chorus clamouring for the army to take on the Maoists. But that is a contentious idea and not a long-term solution.

There has been a growing realisation that any counter-terror force cannot step into the battlefield without training. Unfortunately, training schools are the first casualties in a cost-cutting exercise in any state